Project Brief

Company context, problem, objectives, KPIs, personas and MVP features

Document	00 - Project Brief
Project	AI Customer Support Platform (fictional company: Kestrel Commerce Ltd.)
Prepared by	Project Manager (portfolio author) - self-directed simulation
Status	Simulated baseline v1.0
Project window	5 Jan - 13 Mar 2026 (simulated project window)

SIMULATED PROJECT - Self-directed portfolio case study. Not professional experience, not client work, not employment. All people, figures and outcomes are fictional.

1. Fictional company profile

Company	Kestrel Commerce Ltd. (fictional; any resemblance to a real company is coincidental)
Industry	B2B SaaS: online storefront and order-management platform for small and medium online retailers
Size	About 180 employees; roughly 22,000 active merchant accounts (planning assumption)
Target customers	Merchants with 1-50 staff in North America and Europe; English-language support for the MVP
Business model	Monthly subscription tiers (Starter, Growth, Scale) plus payment-processing fees; support is included in every plan, so it is both a cost centre and a retention driver
Support team	14 agents, 1 team lead, 1 Support Manager and 1 Knowledge & Content Lead

Current support process

Merchants submit a web form or email. Tickets land in a shared helpdesk queue; agents triage, search a static help center of about 320 articles by keyword, and write replies manually. Out-of-hours tickets wait until the next working day, and queues grow after billing cycles and seasonal peaks.

Problems and pain points

- Slow responses: merchants wait hours for answers that already exist in the help center.
- Repetitive work: a large share of tickets are routine how-to, billing and integration set-up questions.
- Poor self-service: keyword search misses relevant articles, so merchants open tickets instead.
- Inconsistent answers between agents and no data on which questions the help center fails to answer.
- Scaling by hiring is expensive and slow; agents report fatigue from repetitive tickets.

Illustrative baseline (fictional planning assumptions, not measured data)

Measure	Baseline assumption
Monthly support tickets	approx. 9,000
Average first response time (email/web form)	6.5 hours
Median time to resolution	22 hours
Share of tickets that are routine (how-to, billing, integration set-up)	approx. 45%
Customer satisfaction (CSAT) on support	3.6 / 5
Support headcount	14 agents, 1 team lead, 1 manager, 1 KB content lead

Why the company wants an AI support platform

Kestrel wants to answer routine questions instantly and around the clock from its own approved content, free agents for complex cases, and learn from unanswered questions. Because wrong answers on billing or data topics could damage merchant trust, leadership wants the AI to be grounded in the knowledge base, to admit when it does not know, and to hand over smoothly to a person.

Business goals

- BG1 Reduce the number of routine tickets that need an agent.
- BG2 Cut response time for merchants.
- BG3 Maintain or improve satisfaction while doing so.
- BG4 Scale support without growing headcount at the same rate.
- BG5 Gain data on content gaps to improve the knowledge base.

2. Problem, vision and objectives

Business problem	Routine questions consume agent capacity and slow responses, raising cost-to-serve and lowering satisfaction.
User problem	Merchants cannot get a fast, trustworthy answer without waiting for a person, and agents spend their day repeating answers.
Problem statement	Merchants with routine questions wait about 6.5 hours (baseline assumption) for answers that already exist in the knowledge base, while agents spend roughly 45% of tickets on repetitive requests, leaving less capacity for complex issues.
Project vision	Every merchant gets a trustworthy, instant answer from Kestrel's own knowledge, or a smooth handover to a person who already has the context.
Project goal	Deliver, within 10 weeks, a pilot-ready AI customer support platform (MVP) with grounded chat answers, human escalation, knowledge-base administration, basic analytics, authentication and privacy controls.

Objectives

#	Objective	Type	How it is measured
BO1	Resolve routine questions without an agent	Business	K1 deflection rate
BO2	Answer in seconds and hand over to a human quickly	Business	K2 response speed
BO3	Give managers evidence to steer support and content	Business	Dashboard live; K4 coverage
UO1	Customers get correct answers with sources	User	Golden-set accuracy; K3 feedback
UO2	Customers can always reach a person without repeating themselves	User	Escalation test pass rate; UAT
UO3	Agents receive context-rich escalations	User	UAT; agent feedback
UO4	Admins maintain content without developers	User	Usability test; UAT

3. Proposed KPIs and success criteria

Every number below is a Proposed Project Target set for this simulation. None of them is an actual result.

Business KPIs (measured after pilot go-live)

ID	KPI	Baseline (assumption)	Proposed Project Target
K1	AI deflection rate (conversations resolved without human handover)	No baseline (new capability)	≥ 35% within 8 weeks of pilot go-live
K2	Response speed	6.5 hours average first response	AI answer p95 ≤ 8 s; first human reply to escalations ≤ 2 business hours
K3	Customer feedback on AI answers	No baseline (new capability)	≥ 75% thumbs-up within 8 weeks of pilot go-live
K4	Knowledge-base coverage of the 20 most frequent ticket categories	Not measured today	≥ 80% of categories have a published, reviewed article at go-live

Go-live criteria (checked in Weeks 9-10)

ID	Criterion	Proposed Project Target	Source
G1	Golden-set answer accuracy	≥ 85%	AIR-02
G2	Unsupported (hallucinated) answers on golden + adversarial sets	≤ 5%	AIR-03
G3	Unanswerable questions that trigger fallback	≥ 95%	AIR-04
G4	p95 response time at 50 concurrent sessions	≤ 8 s, error rate < 1%	NFR-01
G5	UAT test cases passed / open Critical+High defects	≥ 95% / 0	US-28
G6	Open Critical/High security vulnerabilities; PII redaction on seeded test set	0; 100%	SR-05, FR-10
G7	Pilot release date and non-labour budget	11 Mar 2026; ≤ 5,500 USD	BR-07
G8	Story points delivered / Must-have stories delivered	≥ 90% / 100%	Backlog

4. Personas

Persona	Goals	Pain points	Needs	How they use the system
Customer (Maya Chen, owner of a small online ceramics shop)	Needs a quick answer to run her shop (payout timing, integrations, billing) between packing orders.	Waits hours for email replies; help-center search returns poor results; repeats herself to agents.	Instant, correct answer with a source; easy route to a person; no password to remember.	Signs in with an email code, asks questions in the chat window, rates answers, reopens past chats, requests a human when needed.
Customer Support Agent (Jamal Brooks, 2 years in role)	Spend time on complex, valuable cases; resolve each case first time.	Copy-pastes the same answers all day; loses context when a case is passed on; inconsistent answers between colleagues.	Escalations with full transcript and category; a calm, simple queue; clear sign of what the AI already told the customer.	Works the escalation queue: claims an item, reads the transcript, replies, marks it resolved.
Support Manager (Sofia Lindqvist)	Cut backlog and response times without lowering quality; protect the team from burnout.	No visibility of which questions repeat or where content is missing; headcount requests rejected without data.	Trustworthy numbers (deflection, escalation, feedback), list of questions the AI could not answer, control over risk.	Uses the dashboard weekly, reviews sampled AI conversations, leads UAT and signs off.
Admin / Knowledge & Content Lead (Aiden Park)	Keep the knowledge base accurate and current; manage staff access.	Duplicate and outdated articles; no feedback loop; edits depend on developers.	Simple editor, bulk import, publish/unpublish control, visibility of gaps.	Manages articles and roles in the admin area; acts on the fallback-topics report.
Business Stakeholder (Marcus Hale, VP Customer Experience - Sponsor)	Scale support cost-effectively, protect retention and brand, deliver on time and on budget.	Fears wrong AI answers damaging trust; no data to judge the investment.	Clear go/no-go criteria, one-page status, evidence that risk is controlled.	Attends sprint reviews, decides on trade-offs and the Go/No-Go; views summary metrics.

Personas are fictional and written for this simulation; no real users were interviewed.

5. MVP feature catalogue (MoSCoW)

Priorities apply to the 10-week MVP. Story-level acceptance criteria are in 05_User_Stories.xlsx and requirements in 03_Requirements.pdf.

ID	Feature	Description	User	Business value	Priority	Depends on	Feature-level acceptance criteria
F01	Platform Foundation	Environments, CI/CD pipeline and the core data model.	Project team	Safe, repeatable delivery from week 1.	Must	Cloud account and budget	Merge to main deploys to staging automatically; schema builds from an empty database.

ID	Feature	Description	User	Business value	Priority	Depends on	Feature-level acceptance criteria
F02	Authentication & Role-Based Access	Staff sign-in (email + password), customer sign-in (email one-time code), four roles.	All users	Protects data and enables personal history.	Must	F01; email provider	Out-of-role access returns 403; OTP is single-use and expires in 10 minutes.
F03	Knowledge Base Management	Admins create, edit, publish and unpublish articles; bulk import (US-10) is Should.	Admin	Content owned by the business, not by developers.	Must (bulk import: Should)	F01, F02	Published article is searchable by the AI within 5 minutes; invalid import rows are reported.
F04	AI Assistant (RAG, guardrails, evaluation)	Ingestion, retrieval-augmented answers with citations, fallback, out-of-scope handling, PII redaction, golden-set evaluation.	Customer	Deflects routine questions with controlled risk.	Must	F03; provider terms confirmed	Answers cite sources; below-threshold questions fall back to escalation; accuracy and unsupported-answer targets met on the golden set.
F05	Customer Chat Interface	Web chat window with typing indicator, AI label, sources and a visible 'Talk to a person' option; clickable prototype first.	Customer	Instant help in the place customers already look.	Must	F02, F04, UX prototype	Works on latest 4 browsers at 360 px width; keyboard-navigable; WCAG AA contrast on key screens.
F06	Answer Feedback	Thumbs up/down with optional comment on each AI answer.	Customer	Feedback signal for quality and KPI K3.	Should	F05	Rating saved against the answer ID; comment max 500 characters.
F07	Conversation History	Customers see their own conversations from the last 30 days.	Customer	Continuity; fewer repeated questions.	Must	F02, F05	Only own conversations shown; full transcript with sources.
F08	Human Escalation & Agent Console	Customer requests a human; agents work a queue, reply and resolve; customer is notified.	Customer , Agent	Safe route for complex or sensitive issues.	Must	F04, F05	Escalation carries full transcript; claim prevents double handling; customer sees reply within 10 s or by email.
F09	Basic Analytics Dashboard	Event tracking and a manager dashboard (volume, deflection, escalation, feedback, fallback topics).	Support Manager	Measures KPIs and reveals content gaps.	Must	F05, F08	Dashboard figures match the QA test data set; loads in 3 s or less for 30 days.
F10	Security & Privacy Controls	Rate limiting, validation, secrets, scans; 90-day retention and customer-data deletion.	Security & Privacy Officer	Keeps customer data protected and p olicy-compliant.	Must	F01, F02	No Critical/High vulnerabilities at go-live; retention and deletion verified by test.
F11	Audit Logging	Audit log of KB changes and transcript access.	Support Manager	Accountability and investigation.	Should	F02	Entries recorded and filterable by Admin; not editable in UI.
F12	Release Readiness (performance, UAT, deployment)	Load test, UAT, monitoring and rollback, production pilot release.	Sponsor, Support Manager	Confidence to go live without disruption.	Must	F01-F10	Performance, UAT and Go/No-Go criteria met (see Charter).
F13	Guides & Training	Short admin and agent guides and a 60-minute training session.	Agents, Admin	Fast adoption.	Should	F03, F08	Guides of 6 pages or fewer; 90% of attendees finish the practice tasks.

Could Have, Won't Have (this release)

Priority	Item	Reason
Could	KB article version history and restore (US-31)	Useful, not needed for pilot; first candidate if capacity appears.
Could	Sentiment-based automatic escalation (US-32)	Needs separate evaluation; explicit and low-confidence triggers cover the MVP.
Won't	Helpdesk / CRM integration (US-33)	High integration risk for 10 weeks; agent console is standalone.
Won't	Spanish or other languages (US-34)	Raised as CR-001; assessed and deferred.
Won't	Native mobile app or voice channel (US-35)	Responsive web chat is sufficient for the pilot.
Won't	Account-specific actions (refunds, plan changes) by the AI	Legal and security risk; humans handle these.